

The Indie Startup Power Law

What 1,000 payment-verified startups say about where revenue actually lives

59% of them make less than \$1,000 a month.

1,000

startups

65

countries

\$13.5M

monthly recurring

\$334M

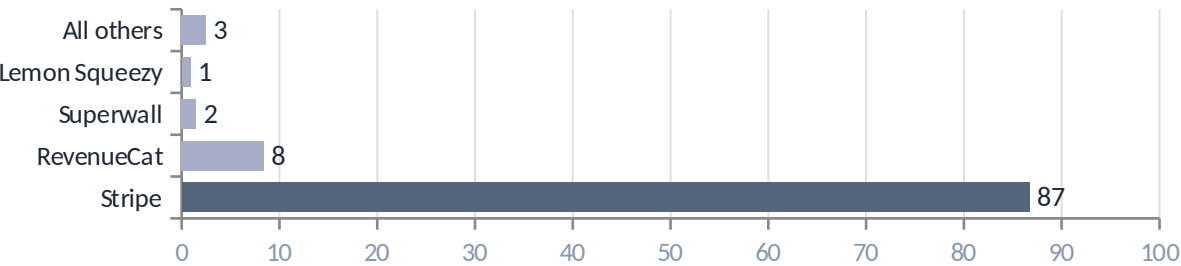
earned all time

Revenue you cannot fake

Founders connect a read-only payment key. Numbers are pulled from the processor, not typed in.



Where the money is processed



Stripe carries 636 listings and 87% of all revenue. RevenueCat and Superwall together are the mobile-app economy — 206 listings, 10% of revenue.

SO WHAT The product is trust, not data. Verification is what turned a weekend build into the default credibility layer for indie startups.

Not used: 22 individual provider strings shown separately. Eleven of them appear on fewer than five listings and add no decision value.

These 1,000 rows are not a sample

Cross-checked against TrustMRR's full 8,782-row file — the same record IDs appear in both

What the 1,000 actually are

11% of all companies on TrustMRR

87.6% of all the monthly revenue on it

\$282 median MRR here — the full file's median is \$0

20% of these rows earn nothing. In the full file, 57% do.

Verified money Complete on every row

Revenue at 30d / 3m / 12m / all-time • MRR • growth % • subscriptions

Reach & authority Visitors missing on 82%

Domain rating • X followers • 30-day visitors • revenue per visitor

Positioning Category missing on 27%

Category • B2B/B2C • pricing model • persona • problem solved

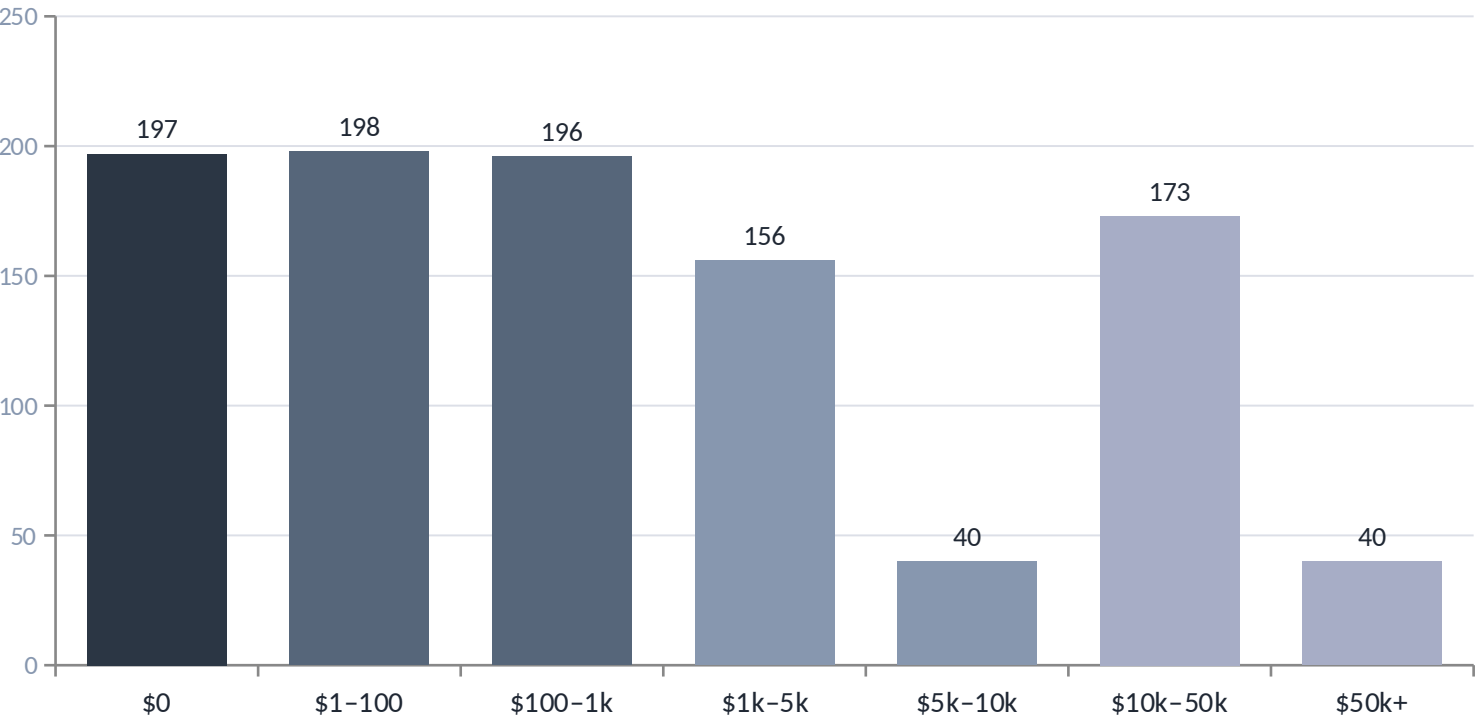
Exit market 262 listings, 26% of rows

For-sale flag • asking price • stated revenue multiple

SO WHAT Every number in this deck describes the top eighth of the market. The floor is worse than anything here shows — treat these as best-case figures.

Almost everyone is earning almost nothing

Distribution of monthly recurring revenue across all 1,000 companies



591

companies — 59% — earn under \$1,000 a month

48x

gap between the median (\$282) and the mean (\$13,472)

59%

have earned under \$10,000 in their entire lifetime

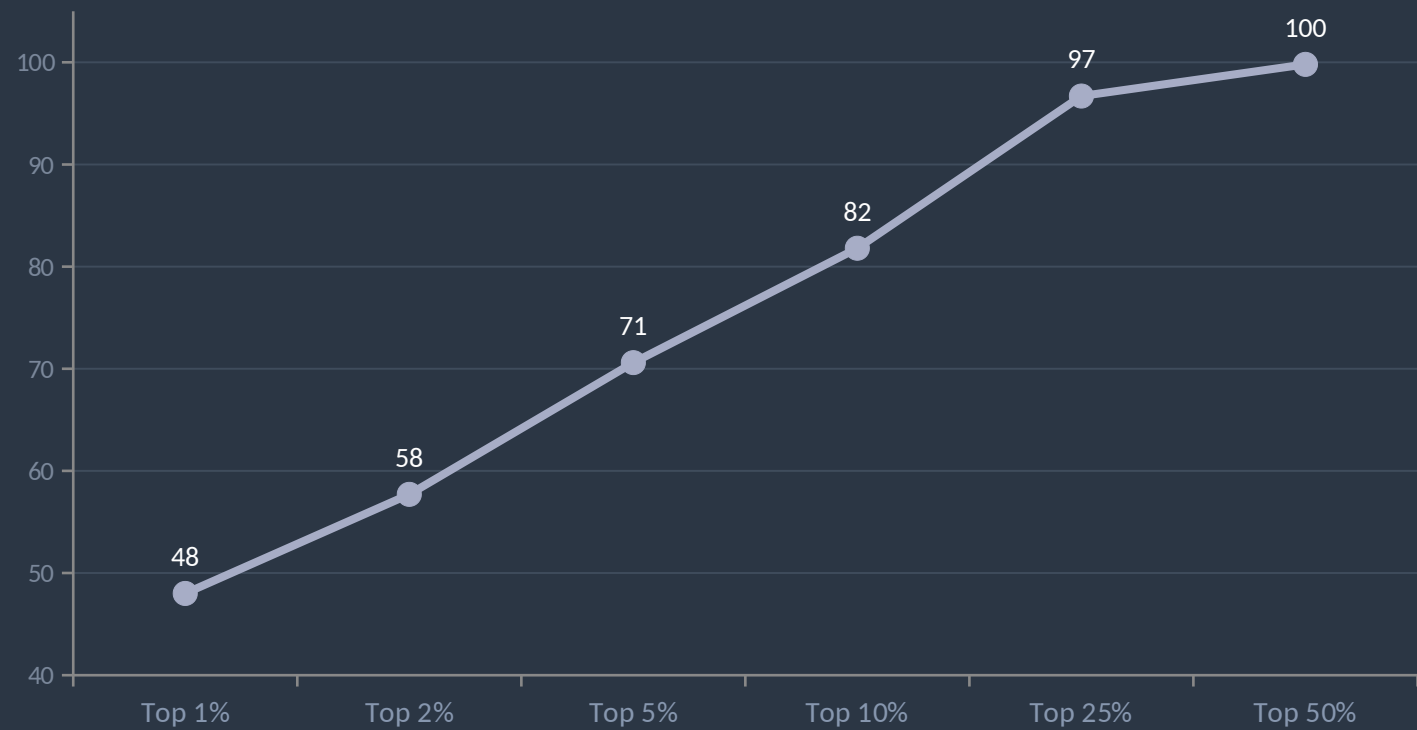
SO WHAT

Every average written about this market is wrong. Building is not the bottleneck here — 80% of these companies shipped something and still charge nobody meaningfully.

Not used: mean MRR as a headline figure. With one company at \$3.57M a month it describes nobody in the dataset.

Ten companies own half the money

Cumulative share of total MRR held by the highest earners



Who they are

Stan	\$3.57M
GojiberryAI	\$495k
Rezi	\$260k
Kibu	\$234k
Cometly	\$208k
1Lookup	\$207k

Stan alone is 26.5% of all MRR in the dataset. Every one of these is US-based.

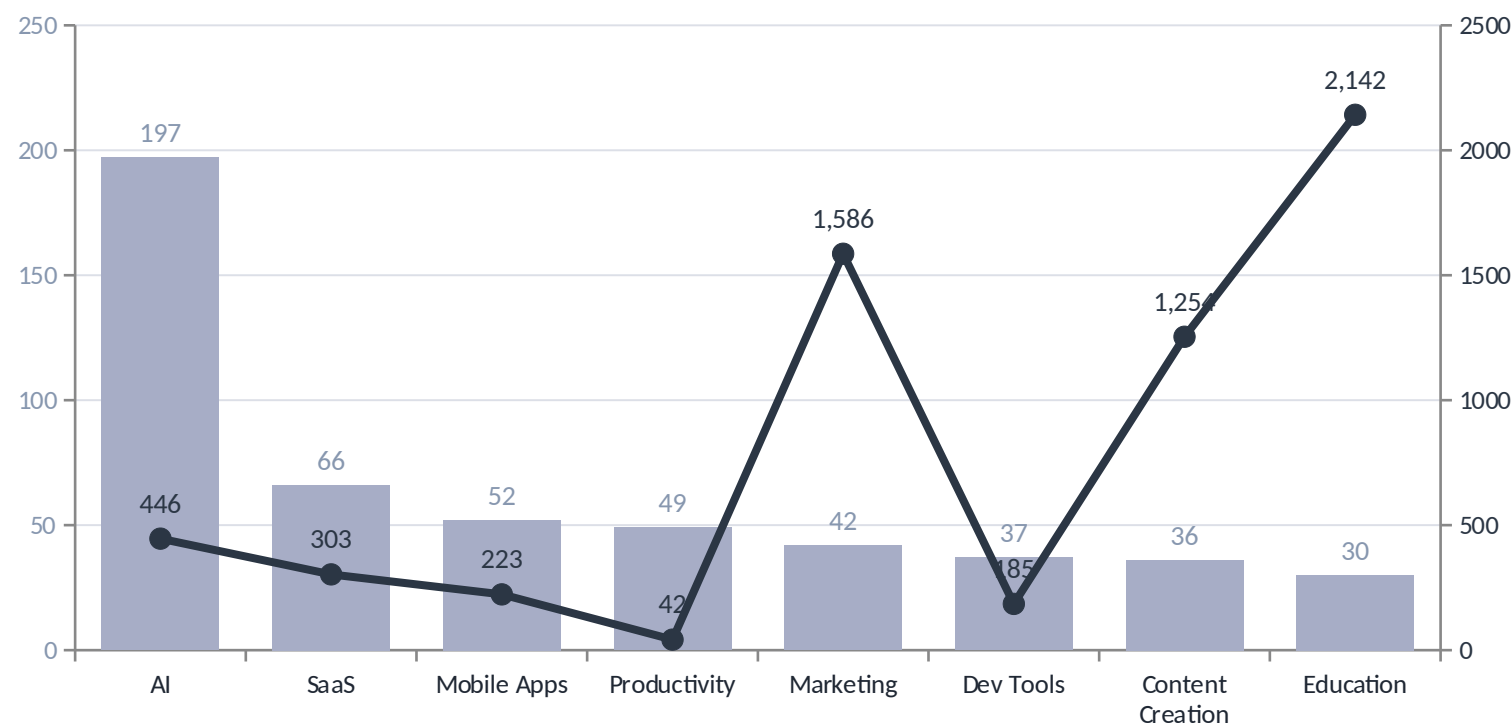
SO WHAT

Do not learn from the outliers. One company holds a quarter of the money — the visible success stories are statistically unrepresentative of the room.

Not used: revenue growth rates at this cut. At these levels a 3,000% jump is \$10 becoming \$310 — the percentage misleads.

The most crowded category is not the best paid

Company count against median monthly revenue — crowding on the left axis, money on the right



AI

197 companies — 4x the next. Median \$446, a fifth of Education's.

Education & Marketing

30 and 42 companies. Medians of \$2,142 and \$1,586 — the best-paid work nobody is doing.

Productivity

49 companies, median \$42 a month. The worst bet on the board.

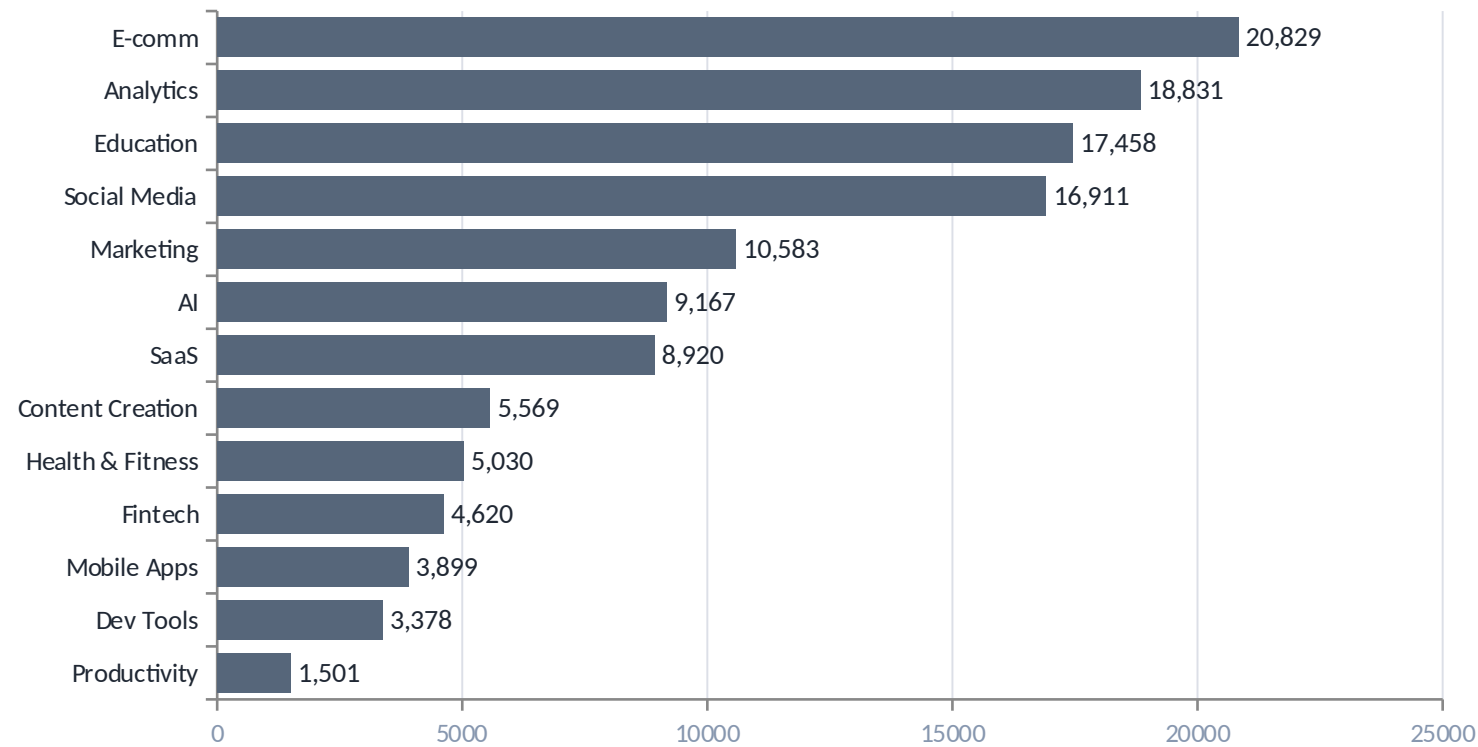
SO WHAT

Crowding is supply of founders, not demand from customers. Where the grey bar is tall and the dark line is low, the market is being over-served.

Not used: 21 categories with fewer than 15 companies. Medians on samples that small are noise — one shows \$9,073 off seven listings.

Where the winners get biggest

Mean MRR per company — in a power law, the mean measures the size of the tail



Education is the standout

30 companies, mean \$17,458 and median \$2,142. High on both measures — rare.

E-comm and Analytics are lottery tickets

Highest means on the board, but built on 19 companies each. Read the ceiling, not the odds.

Productivity is the trap

49 companies, mean \$1,501, median \$42. Easiest to build, hardest to charge for.

SO WHAT

Read slides 6 and 7 together. Education is the only category that is both well paid at the median and large at the mean — and it has 30 companies in it.

Categories with n ≥ 15 only. Mean is inflated by outliers by design — that is exactly what it is being used to measure here.

Two corrections the data makes to how founders position

Both sit in columns most people skip past

AI is a layer, not a market

197

call AI their primary category

392

apply AI to something else

Twice as many companies treat AI as a capability as claim it as a category — and the ones with a real vertical earn more. "AI" is not a market you can sell into.

Everyone builds B2C. B2B pays.

	B2B	B2C
Companies	255	401
Median MRR	\$1,036	\$181
Mean MRR	\$13,150	\$5,102
Revenue per customer	\$49.00	\$9.34

5.7x the median revenue, 5.2x per customer, on 36% fewer attempts.

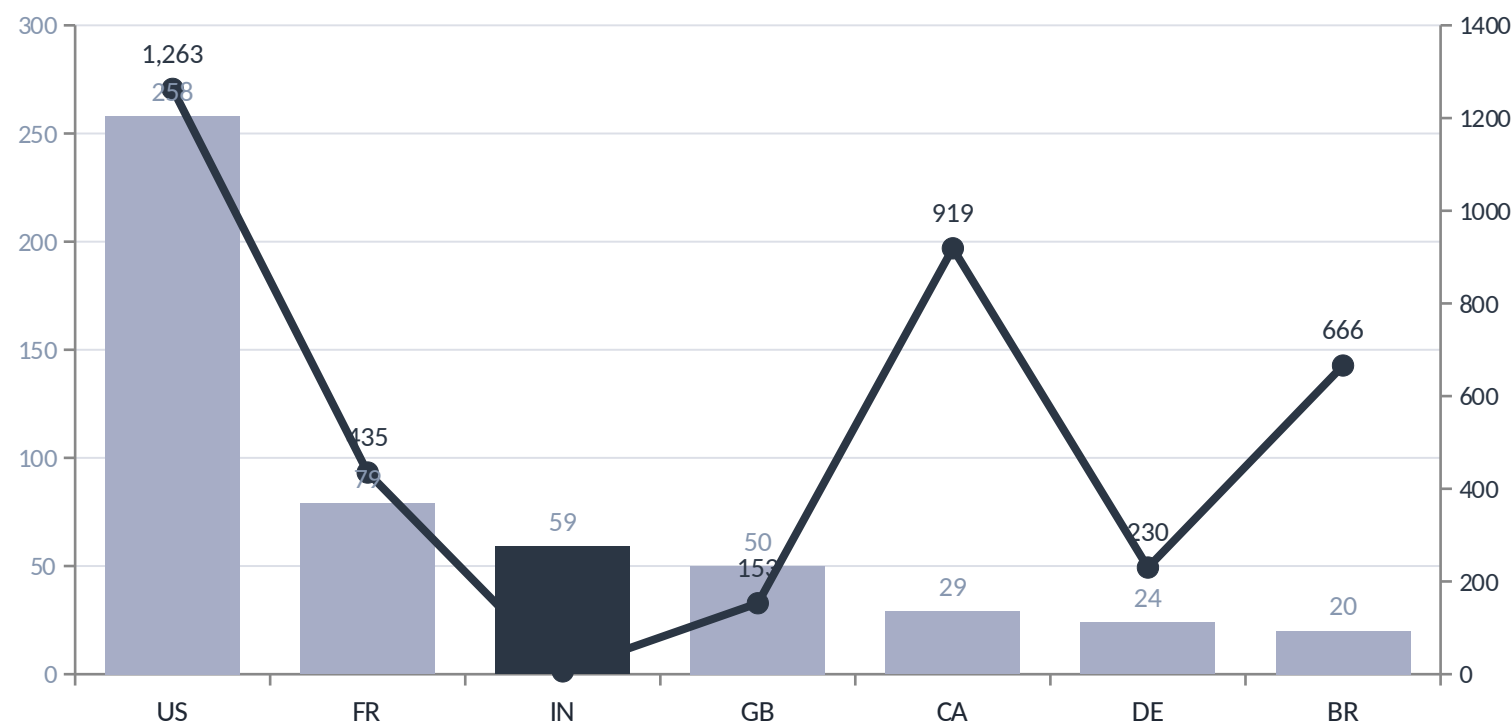
SO WHAT

Not "build an AI product" — apply AI to a business that already pays for something. B2B-first, vertical-first.

Not used: the "Both" audience segment (56 companies). Too small to separate and it blurs the contrast that drives the decision.

India ships in volume and earns almost nothing

Company count against median monthly revenue, for countries with 20+ listings



The gap

210x

between the median US and median Indian startup here

1.2%

of all MRR is Indian, on 5.9% of the companies

59%

of Indian listings earn anything — against 88% for the US

SO WHAT

India is third by volume and last by earnings among serious markets. Indian builders have shipping ability and no monetization ability — that is a fixable gap, not a talent gap.

Not used: 58 countries with under 20 listings, and 241 rows with no country recorded. Both too thin to compare fairly.

Distribution beats audience

Median values: the 212 companies above \$10k MRR against the 591 below \$1k

	Under \$1k	Above \$10k	Log correlation
Active subscriptions	2	555	0.82
30-day visitors	420	11,622	0.39
Domain rating	4	35	0.51
X followers	40	163	0.16

The domain a founder picks says more than the following they built. X followers is the weakest correlate on the board — and the one founders spend the most time on.

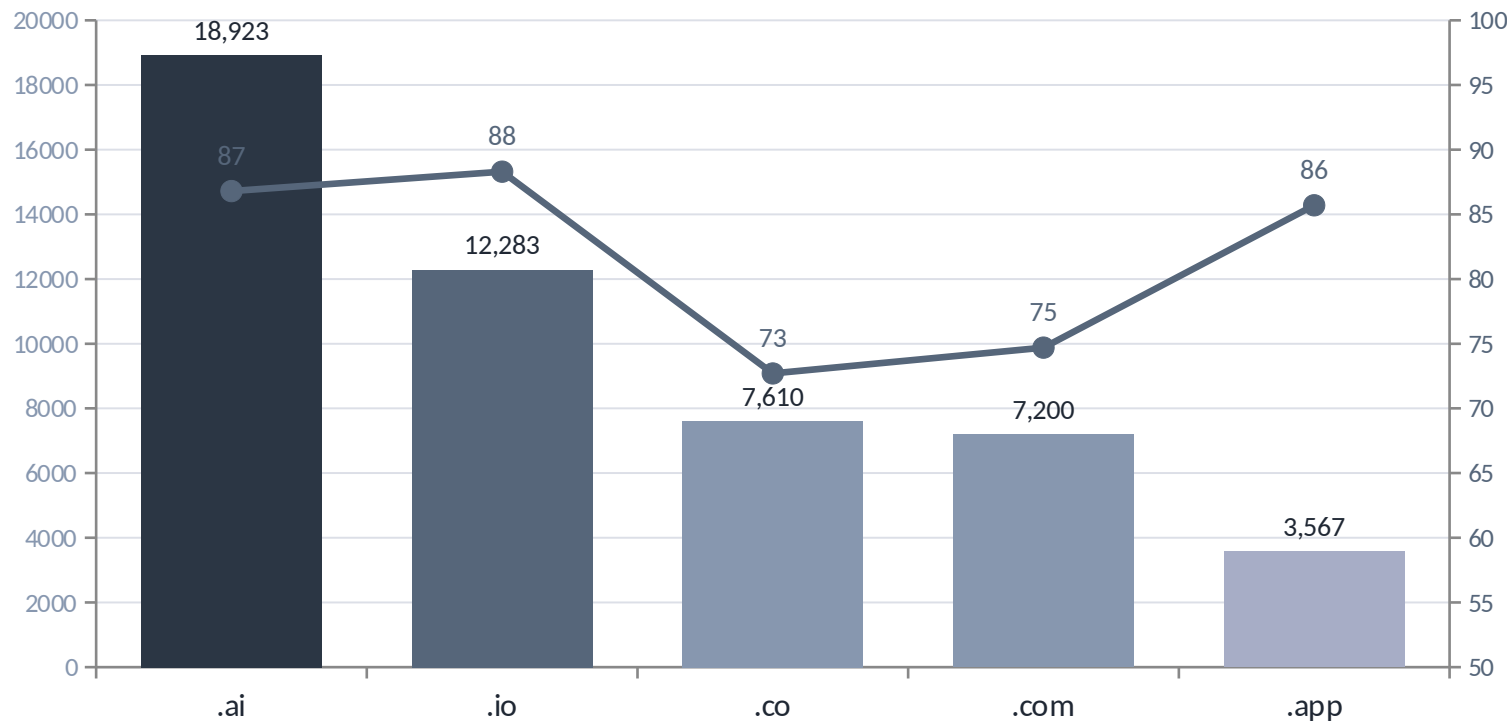
SO WHAT

Build distribution before product. Paying subscriptions and search authority predict revenue; audience size barely does.

Correlations are weak to moderate and computed on log values across earning companies. Read this as a pattern worth acting on, not a formula.

The extension a founder buys predicts what they earn

Mean MRR and share monetized, by top-level domain



Read it as selection, not cause

Buying a .ai does not make money appear. But it costs roughly 20x a .com, and paying that is the first evidence a founder intends to charge for something.

.app is the cheap default — highly monetized, but at a fifth of .ai's mean.

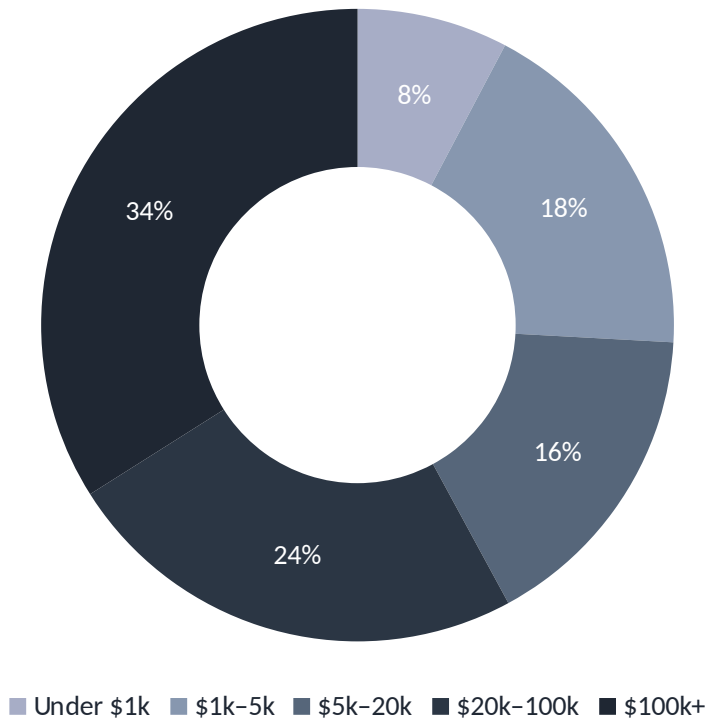
.com is the largest group at 312 domains and lands mid-table on both measures.

SO WHAT

The cheapest signal of seriousness in the whole dataset costs about \$70 a year — and it separates cohorts better than follower count does.

One listing in four is quietly for sale

262 companies carry an asking price — 26% of the dataset



\$35,000
median asking price

3.18x
median multiple of ARR

31%
of listings are priced under \$10,000 — a working business with verified revenue for the price of a laptop and a holiday

These are assets, not corpses

For-sale listings earn 3.3x the dataset median over twelve months — \$7,967 against \$2,416. Founders here list working products because they are bored, not because the product died.

SO WHAT
Buying beats building at this end of the market. A 3.18x ARR anchor on a verified P&L is cheaper than eighteen months of guessing.

Not used: asking prices above \$1M in the median, and stated revenue multiples running past 300x with no diligence behind them.

Six moves this data supports

For anyone choosing what to build next

01 Quote medians, never averages

Median \$282 · mean \$13,472 · a 48x gap

02 Pick the category by its median

Education \$2,142 vs Productivity \$42

03 Treat AI as a layer on a vertical

392 apply it · only 197 sell it

04 Go B2B first

\$1,036 vs \$181 median · \$49 vs \$9.34 per customer

05 Build distribution before product

Subscriptions 0.82 · domain rating 0.51 · followers 0.16

06 Consider buying instead of building

262 listings · 31% under \$10,000 · 3.18x ARR

The data does not say building is hard. It says charging is.